

PRIMORDIAL

Wars of the Elements

A Fast Mass-Battle Miniatures Game

Ages 8+ • 2 players • d20 combat

Rules v0.3 • Core Rules • Two Starter Armies • Quick Reference

The Idea

Two players build armies from a shared pool of points, line them up, and fight. The aim is the speed and readability of a board game married to the army-building and tactics of a miniatures wargame. Every roll uses a twenty-sided die (d20). In a fight, both sides roll a handful of dice, and the defending player decides how to match them up — a fast, strategic exchange with no sorting and no fiddly tables.

Win condition: destroy your opponent's army, or end with the stronger force when you both agree the battle is decided.

Building an Army

Both players agree a points limit, then spend up to that total. Starter games use 100 points (try 50 for a quick game with younger players). Spend points however you like — one giant block of infantry, a swarm of fast cavalry, a wall of archers, or a mix.

Unit Types

Type	Cost	Move	Attack	Armor	Special
Infantry	1 ea	5"	+0	—	The backbone. Cheap, steady, strong in deep ranks.
Archers	2 ea	5"	+0 shoot / -2 melee	—	Range 10". Shoot before the lines meet. Weak up close.
Cavalry	3 ea	10"	+2 (+4 charge)	+2	Deadlier than infantry even before the charge.

Champions. For +2 points, upgrade one model in a unit to a Champion, up to one per 5 models. In any fight that unit is in, a Champion lets you add +2 to one of your own dice after rolling. Champions die like normal models.

Heroes coming later. *A future version will add larger-than-life, mounted Captains/Heroes tied to a fantasy setting and a battle of the elements. For now the game runs on the three core troop types so it stays simple to learn and test.*

Forming Units

The rank of 5 is the building block. Every unit is one or more ranks of 5 models lined up behind one another; the minimum unit is one rank (5). You decide how to split your models before the game: 20 infantry could be one block of 20, two units of 10, or four units of 5.

Frontage. Only the front rank fights, so a unit rolls at most 5 dice in a single combat. Extra ranks don't add dice — they add the Rank Bonus.

Rank Bonus. For each full rank of 5 behind the front rank, the unit adds +1 to every die it rolls — on attack AND on defense — up to a maximum of +3. So 5 models = +0, 10 = +1, 15 = +2, 20 or more = +3. This is why deep blocks both hit harder and hold firmer.

The Turn

Attacker and defender. Combat is one-sided each turn. On your turn your engaged units are the attackers and the enemy defends, so your Attack stats are tested against their Defense stats and only the defending side loses models. Your opponent strikes back on their turn. Shooting and melee use the same procedure.

On your turn, do these steps in order, then pass play to your opponent:

1. Move — move any of your units (charges are declared here).
2. Shoot — your archers fire at enemy units within range.
3. Fight — resolve every melee where your units touch the enemy.

Movement

Each model type has a Move value in inches (the included measuring stick is 5 units long — one stick is an infantry move, two sticks a cavalry move). A unit that moves into base contact with an enemy is charging.

- Big and slow: a unit of 15 or more models can't turn (pivot) and move in the same turn — it repositions or advances straight, not both.
- Cavalry are fast (10") and get their Charge bonus only on the turn they actually reach the enemy.

Resolving a Fight (shooting or melee)

Both shooting and melee use this one procedure. You are the attacker; the enemy defends.

1. Roll the dice. Each side rolls one d20 per model in the fight — for melee, the front-rank models in base contact; for shooting, the archers shooting and the target's front rank. Maximum 5 dice per side.
2. Add modifiers. Add your ATTACK modifiers to your dice. The defender adds their DEFENSE modifiers to theirs. A Champion may add +2 to one of its owner's dice.
3. Defender assigns. Lay the attacker's dice out as rolled (no sorting). The DEFENDER pairs each of their dice against an attacker die of their choice. The defender decides who takes which blow.
4. Resolve. In each pair, if the attacker's total BEATS the defender's total, that defending model is removed. A tie or a higher defender total means it survives.
5. Overwhelm. If the attacker has MORE dice than the defender (you brought more models to bear, or hit a flank), each extra attacker die with no defender paired to it removes one model automatically.

Only the defender loses models — your attackers are safe this turn; the enemy hits back on theirs. Letting the defender choose the matchups is the key skill: spend your strong dice to block the deadliest attacker dice and decide which models you can afford to lose.

Worked example. Your 5 Cavalry charge a unit of 10 Infantry. Your attack mod is +6 (Attack +2 and Charge +4); the infantry defend at +1 (one full rank behind). Attacker totals: 18, 16, 14, 11, 9. Defender rolls totals: 18, 16, 10, 9, 7. The defender assigns cleverly — 18 blocks the 18 (tie, survives), 16 blocks the 14 (survives), 10 blocks the 9 (survives); the remaining 9 and 7 can't

stop the attacker's 16 and 11, so two infantry fall. Smart assignment loses 2; pairing high-to-high would have lost 3.

Shooting Notes

- Archers shoot in the Shoot step, before any melee, at +0. Range is 10" (two measuring sticks).
- No shooting into melee: archers can't fire at a unit already locked in combat.
- Archers take no return fire — only the target loses models.

Unequal Numbers

Each side always rolls one die per model it actually has in the fight (max 5). You do not get bonus defense dice. If the attacker has more dice than the defender, the extra dice are automatic hits (Overwhelm). If the defender has more models than the attacker has dice, the surplus models simply aren't struck this turn — they fight on their own turn. A 2-model unit attacking a fresh rank of 5 fights at 2 dice vs 2: parity now, but the bigger unit kills back next turn. Numbers win through frontage, flanking, and Overwhelm — not bonus dice.

Attack Modifiers (your dice, on your turn)

Modifier	Effect
Attack value	Cavalry +2, Infantry +0, Archers +0 shooting / -2 in melee.
Cavalry Charge	+4 to a cavalry unit's dice on the turn it reaches the enemy (on top of its +2 Attack).
Rank Bonus	+1 per full rank behind the front, max +3.
Champion (+2 pts)	Add +2 to one of your dice after rolling. Max one per 5 models.
Flank / rear attack	Hit the enemy's side or rear: they lose their Rank Bonus and take -4 on defense.

Defense Modifiers (your dice, on the enemy's turn)

Modifier	Effect
Armor	Cavalry +2. Heavier troops (a later addition) +4. Infantry & Archers +0.
Rank Bonus	+1 per full rank behind the front, max +3 — applies on defense too.
Champion (+2 pts)	Add +2 to one of your defense dice after rolling.
Flanked / rear	If hit in the side or rear: no Rank Bonus and -4 to your defense dice.

Why Both Big and Small Units Matter

The design pulls in two directions on purpose:

- Big blocks are durable and steady. The Rank Bonus (up to +3) helps on attack and defense, and with the defender choosing matchups a deep block bleeds slowly instead

of getting wiped — a reliable anvil. But it rolls only 5 dice, turns slowly, and a flank strips its Rank Bonus.

- Small units are nimble. Fragile, but they move freely, threaten several fronts, and can flank or rear (no Rank Bonus, -4) to crack a block head-on combat can't.
- Cavalry are the can-opener. Fast, Attack +2, +4 on the charge, Armor +2.
- Archers set the terms. They thin a front rank from 10" away, but melt in melee — screen them with infantry.
- Initiative matters: only the attacker deals casualties on a turn, so charging first and choosing your fight is a real edge.

Where This Is Going

Planned additions, each slotting into the same dice engine without new math: larger-than-life mounted Captains/Heroes (multiple Wounds, a leadership aura, a signature attack); a single big Monster; heavy armor (+4); terrain and objectives; and an elemental fantasy theme — armies aligned to elements (fire, water, earth, air) with matchup bonuses, e.g. water units defending better against fire. This is the likely direction once playtesting settles the core.

Quick Reference Card

Turn Order

1) Move → 2) Shoot → 3) Fight

Resolve a Fight (shoot or melee)

Both roll d20 = models in the fight (max 5). Add your attack mods to your dice, the defender's defense mods to theirs. The DEFENDER pairs their dice against the attacker's dice (their choice). Attacker total beats defender total → that model dies; tie or lower survives. Extra attacker dice (more dice than the defender) = automatic hits. Only the defender loses models.

Attack Modifiers

Modifier	Value
Attack — Cavalry / Infantry / Archers	+2 / +0 / +0 (−2 melee)
Cavalry Charge (turn it reaches enemy)	+4
Rank Bonus (per full rank behind front)	+1 each, max +3
Champion (one die, after rolling)	+2
Hit enemy flank / rear (strips their Rank Bonus, −4 to them)	—

Defense Modifiers

Modifier	Value
Armor — Cavalry / heavy (later) / others	+2 / +4 / +0
Rank Bonus (per full rank behind front)	+1 each, max +3
Champion (one die, after rolling)	+2
Flanked / rear (no Rank Bonus)	−4

Key Numbers

Moves: Infantry/Archers 5", Cavalry 10". Archer range 10". Measuring stick = 5 units. Costs: Infantry 1 • Archer 2 • Cavalry 3 • Champion +2 (max 1 per 5). Starter game 100 pts (50 for quick play).

Starter Army — Ironhold Legion

The anvil. Deep blocks of disciplined infantry that grind the enemy down, screened by archers with a single hammer of knights. Slow, tough, relentless.

Unit	Models	Champions	Cost
1st Spears (Infantry, 4 ranks)	20	4	28
2nd Spears (Infantry, 3 ranks)	15	3	21
3rd Spears (Infantry, 2 ranks)	10	0	10
Archer Company (2 ranks)	10	2	24
Knights (Cavalry, 1 rank)	5	1	17

Total: 100 points

Starter Army — Wyldwood Host

The scalpel. Massed archers thin the enemy at range while fast riders sweep the flanks. Fragile head-on — wins by never giving a fair fight.

Unit	Models	Champions	Cost
Glade Archers A (2 ranks)	10	2	24
Glade Archers B (2 ranks)	10	1	22
Glade Archers C (1 rank)	5	0	10
Wild Riders (Cavalry)	5	1	17
Storm Riders (Cavalry)	5	1	17
Wardens (Infantry, 2 ranks)	10	0	10

Total: 100 points